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Introduction: Mobile Soldiers and the Un-National Liberation of Southern Africa

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What follows began in conversations over beer in Lusaka several years ago. That point of origin is important because what we have sought to do here is to make the anecdotes about national liberation – the stuff of bar talk – a subject matter in and of themselves. As we chatted about the Zimbabwe African People's Union (ZAPU) having a larger army in 1970s Zambia than Zambia did, and observed that Umkhonto we Sizwe (MK) never actually sent a regiment into South Africa, while Ron Reid-Daly, founder and myth-maker of the Selous Scouts, boasted that his regiment contained not only men from the US and New Zealand but turned guerrillas who had been trained in Bulgaria and the USSR, we wondered why such material went largely unremarked in scholarship. It was understood that the liberation of southern African nations involved more than one country, so why was it that 20 years after the end of apartheid, scholars still write about the liberation of southern African countries as if the frame of the nation – and the documents it produced – was all that one needed? The very notion of 'national liberation', which has underwritten 40 years of scholarship in general, and in the *Journal of Southern African Studies* in particular, has given primacy to a framework that arguably had limited relevance to players on both sides of the conflict, many of whom were motivated by – among other things – broader ideological notions of change, ethno-regional allegiances, personal advancement and access to education. The notion of a single one-way journey from tyranny to national liberation has arguably restricted the development of a more open-ended, fragmented and inclusive set of conflict histories in southern Africa compared to those that exist for East and Central Africa.[1]

We challenged a small group of scholars to write histories of national liberation in frames that were both transnational and un-national. To this end, we organised a workshop at the University of Sheffield in March 2013; the five articles published here are revised versions of

1 Compare, for example, the wealth and diversity of analyses of Mau Mau, starting from B. Berman and J. Lonsdale, *Unhappy Valley: Conflict in Kenya and Africa*, 2 vols. (Oxford, James Currey, 1992), and including D. Anderson, *Histories of the Hanged: The Dirty War in Kenya and the End of Empire* (New York, Norton, 2005), and D. Branch, *Defeating Mau Mau, Creating Kenya: Counterinsurgency, Civil War, and Decolonization* (Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, 2009). On Central Africa, see, for example, R. Lemarchand, *The Dynamics of Violence in Central Africa* (Philadelphia, University of Pennsylvania Press, 2009); G. Prunier, *Africa's World War: Congo, the Rwandan Genocide, and the Making of a Continental Catastrophe* (London, Hurst, 2009); K. Vlassenroot and T. Raeymakers (eds), *Conflict and Social Transformation in Eastern DR Congo* (Ghent, Academica Press, 2004); S. Marysse and F. Reyntjens (eds), *L'Afrique des Grand Lacs*, various editions (Paris, L'Harmattan, various years).

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some of the papers presented there.[2] These articles offer new, dynamic ways to think about processes that were never fully national, often unpacking histories that have been presented as smooth and successful, to show the facets and fault lines of the many nations operating in these transnational and un-national spaces.[3] To do this, their authors used an extraordinary set of sources – diaries of protagonists, new oral histories and the records of the TRC – most of which could not be contained in any 'national' archive.

Liberation armies in exile had a variety of political backstories of great complexity – for example, SWAPO's alliance with UNITA, analysed by Vilho **Shigwedha**, before making a binding shift to the MPLA – and the question of who went into exile and how they got there was worth close examination. The problem of how to go from one country to another, or two others, was not straightforward. Border-crossing was not simply the first step towards guerrilla struggle; it was an event and social process in and of itself. As Luise **White**'s article shows, crossing one border without arrest or harassment did not guarantee that someone could move freely across another border: staying on the other side, and going for guerrilla training or anything else, required a narrative and being accepted by a political party in exile; in some cases it required an empathic if not sympathetic or clued-in Special Branch. Borders did not always stay open for the youths who crossed them. The legal status with which men in British territories crossed borders determined where they could enter again, and the men who fled Katanga in the early 1960s crossed a border across which United Nations and Congolese national army troops could not follow, but which they themselves could not easily recross.[4] The movement of people across borders was not the only transnational transition taking place, however. Borders moved through time and across people and political affiliations;[5] decolonization could make British protected persons into citizens of Botswana and Malawi, for example, just as Rhodesia's unilateral declaration of independence (UDI) complicated the status of Rhodesian Africans, both in southern Africa and in Britain. The disputed border between Namibia and Angola, and the ambiguous frontier in the first years after the Carnation Revolution, created shifts in loyalties that seemed to participants a natural part of the political landscape. Patricia **Hayes** and Vilho Shigwedha recount stories of men who thought they were Angolan, but joined SWAPO when they learned that they were Namibian nationals. No one thought twice about such changes, but when donor countries shifted their affiliation, or when the UN made one party and not another the authentic liberation movement, new histories of age-old rivalries were constructed.

We coined the term 'un-national' to underscore how much of national liberation took place in and from spaces that were categorically different from the national frame. Luise White describes the world of Special Branch and refugees in Francistown, Botswana as a middle ground, a place separate from nations and parties and wars. Steve **Davis**'s article on Novo Catengue, an MK camp in Angola, argues that it is not separate from wars and nations, but that the interactions there are best understood by looking at everyday life rather than ideas about nation-building or commitment to armed struggle. It is Nicky **Rousseau**'s article that perhaps charts the clearest demarcation of the national and un-national. The Soweto Intelligence Unit was a South African police body that recruited undercover agents and

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2 We wish to thank the Center for African Studies, University of Oxford, and the Office of Research, University of Florida, and *JSAS* for their financial support of the workshop.

3 Other researchers who made presentations at the workshop have also addressed these themes in their work: see, for example, G. Baines, *South Africa's 'Border War': Contested Narratives and Conflicting Memories* (London, Bloomsbury, 2014); C.A. Williams, *Camp, Nation, History: An Historical Ethnography of the SWAPO Camps, the Southern African Region and the International System* (Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, forthcoming).

4 E. Kennes and M. Larmer, *Fighting Their Way Home: The Katangese Gendarmes and War in Central Africa* (forthcoming).

5 We take this notion from R. Brubaker, 'Migration, Membership, and the Modern Nation-State: Internal and External Dimensions of the Politics of Belonging', *Journal of Interdisciplinary History*, 41, 1 (2010), pp. 61–78.

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informers. Its officers were not only South Africans but also former Rhodesians, Mozambicans and at least one Botswanan, aided by informers and double agents of various nationalities. They all sought to undermine ANC activities wherever they took place; their jurisdiction was regional. To paraphrase Rousseau, and to parody Rhodesian counter-insurgency rhetoric, if the entire world was against the white-ruled nation, the entire world was fair game for repression.

We did not intend un-national as a buzz word; instead we wanted a term that would allow us to engage the complexities of what was national about national liberation. If we start our analysis in the Protea police station in Soweto or Special Branch headquarters in Francistown or a prison cell in Ondjiva, what do we see? The region that was Botswana, Rhodesia, Namibia and South Africa – at least – becomes something more than what can adequately or accurately be described as transnational. It becomes a space in which regional struggles shape modes of belonging, as Rousseau and Hayes both point out: these modes do not simply determine who is Namibian and who is Angolan, but who can cross another border to go for guerrilla training, who can be called a refugee, and who is sent back to the country he fled. Indeed, the place where the nation seems most thoroughly inscribed was not the police stations of South Africa in the 1980s, but MK's Novo Catengue camp in Angola.

Rousseau's article raises the question of jurisdiction, a question that itself charts a space between borders and nations. Jurisdiction extends not just over territories, but over people. In this case the people are soldiers, or men who want to be soldiers while pretending they want to be something else. Who had the legal authority to discipline these men? In the case of Godfrey Nangonya – the immediate subject of Patricia Hayes' article – the answer was 'almost everyone': the Portuguese imprisoned him twice before 1975 and the Angolans imprisoned him twice after 1975. Special Branch in Francistown, however, often relied on ZAPU in Lusaka to find out who was an authentic ZAPU member and who was not. In Novo Catengue the MK commanders could discipline cadres, but it was not clear how. There were debates about drill: did it instil discipline or indiscipline? Did the men whom camp commanders shuddered to admit were hardened criminals require drill at all? If they were infiltrated back into South Africa, would they return to a life of crime? Once a contingent of Cuban instructors arrived, the camp was supposed to be administered jointly, but in fact the Cubans made all the decisions about security and training, and kept weapons under lock and key. Indeed, with their separate and better living conditions, and their superior weaponry and access to decision-makers, Cuban officers looked a lot like their Portuguese predecessors in the camps, who had commanded both Angolan and Congolese forces in their 15-year war against three Angolan liberation movements operating across numerous borders and backed by independent African states and by superpowers. Namibia's disputed border with Angola – during and after Portuguese rule – and its occupation by South Africa made jurisdiction transnational: the Portuguese secret police, the PIDE, could and did submit a request to the South African police, who proved only too willing to arrest those nationalists whom the Portuguese wanted to see behind bars.

But who was a nationalist, who was a soldier and who was a refugee? 'Refugee' was sometimes a term of convenience, sometimes a legal (and legally enforced) category. The difference between who was a guerrilla and who was a refugee was never fixed, whatever the law said; each term provided different openings and opportunities when used by liberation armies and counter-insurgency forces.[6] These articles demand that we ask to whom these terms mattered. If men in camps in Angola never fought as an army, do we worry about calling them guerrillas? And Godfrey Nangonya did not carry a weapon in

6 The canonical distinction, used in preparation for Zimbabwe's 1980 election, was that guerrillas returned to the country armed, refugees were unarmed. See L. White, *Unpopular Sovereignty: Rhodesian Independence and African Decolonization* (Chicago, University of Chicago Press, forthcoming 2015).

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battle, but his story provides a lens through which to complicate narratives of national liberation. And complicated they were, for all concerned. Special Branch in Francistown identified guerrillas by the stories they told, the histories they brought across the border, the weapons they carried and sometimes the shoes they wore. For soldiers in the People's Liberation Army of Namibia (PLAN), the Forças Armadas Populares de Libertação de Angola (FAPLA), and the União Nacional para a Independência Total de Angola (UNITA), the fact of being a cadre was secondary to the army a soldier had previously supported: history rather than legal status shaped interactions in camps and battlefield.

All of this might help us to think anew about guerrillas and the armies they fought in – or did not fight in – and their enemies in the security forces of South Africa, Rhodesia and the Portuguese colonies. Who they were was not wholly a national issue, as Hayes and Shigwedha make clear, and the entire transnational project of going into exile often required that cadres dissembled, either downplaying what Special Branch called their 'guerrilla *bona fides*' or exaggerating them. Those who fought against national liberation often described their struggle as one against communism, terrorism, or some kind of alliance born in the UN. Years ago, Benedict Anderson pointed out that such terms erased '*nation-ness*' so that the struggle became a racial or political embodiment.[7] At the same time, however, these white soldiers proclaimed their personal loyalties to their comrades-in-arms, some of whom were of different racial and national origin from themselves. Ideological affiliations could exist alongside such personalised allegiances and more pragmatic considerations, such as personal gain or acts of revenge or retribution. But this was also true for some of those who found themselves fighting for the liberation armies. Dissembling may explain how the thieves and criminals found their way to Novo Catengue and other training camps in Angola, but it does not fully explain how the defeated remnants of Holden Roberto's Frente Nacional de Libertação de Angola (FNLA) became the basis of the 32 Battalion of the South African Defence Force (SADF). We suggest that the idea of identity, either national or political, does not allow us a full understanding of who goes into exile with which army. Motivations and mobilisations, overlapping and shifting in response to circumstance, provide a better way to consider the realities of guerrilla struggles. What these articles offer is a way to think about soldiers' mobility – even when that mobility is between prisons – that shows the importance of region and history in what is not wholly national liberation.

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7 B. Anderson, *Imagined Communities: Reflections on the Origin and Spread of Nationalism* (London, Verso, 1983), p. 135. Italics in original.

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